

"The first step of treatment begins at home... If it does not work, then seek a doctor's consultation to draw up a personalised treatment plan"

Dr Sandeep Vohra
Psychiatrist and founder, Vohra Neuro Psychiatry Centre, Delhi

Brain fog, however, severely disturbs the quality and length of sleep, found a 2021 *PubMed* study of 500 patients. To counter this, doctors stress the importance of setting a daily routine. "Your body clock gets adjusted to sleeping and waking up at a particular time, and one should not disturb it," says Dr Sehgal. If one has trouble falling asleep, the UK's National Health Service recommends a wind-down routine—eating three hours before bed, turning off screens an hour before sleep, writing down worries, and practising mindfulness or meditation. Harsh Chauhan (*name changed*), a 39-year-old management consultant, found that doing puzzles helped him fall asleep post-Covid, and sleep reduced his anxiety and brain fog. "I rested my way to recovery from brain fog. It is a cycle—you feel unhappy and can't sleep, and because you can't sleep, you can't feel happy," he says. He also slowly returned to exercising.

Doctors say patients often confuse movement with exercise. Light movement can play a role in mitigating stress, perception of pain and modulation of brain functions by releasing endorphins. "Movement is important but not heavy exercise," says Dr Srivastava. "People with long-Covid symptoms should rest for three months before returning to the gym so that the body gets time to heal." A study published in May 2021 in the *Journal of Chronic Respiratory Disease* concluded that those who went through a supervised rehabilitation period showed better improvement in cognitive function than those who did not. The Johns Hopkins University's detailed guide for post-Covid rehabilitation recommends five pillars—breathing, movement of head and eyes, cross-body patterns such as walking, strength training and endurance. In the first few weeks post-Covid, it recommends no more than five minutes of cardio, gradually building up to 30 minutes after the first two months.

The brain also needs essential nutrients during recovery. Doctors recommend a diet rich in vitamin B12, vitamin E and antioxidants. Consuming nuts, dairy products and fish, which are rich in serotonin, can help overcome weakness, repair cells and improve mood. "If your symptoms indicate mild brain fog and tests confirm it, then I usually start by recommending lifestyle changes, including better nutrition and proper rest," says Dr Renjen.

Doctors also suggest some attention to mental health. "This does not necessarily mean you have to go for therapy or take medicines," says Dr Sandeep Vohra, psychiatrist and founder of the Vohra Neuro Psychiatry Centre in Delhi. Having treated many patients suffering from post-Covid anxiety or depression, Dr Vohra says sometimes the conditions were pre-existing and the illness aggravated them. "They can also be caused by the illness if there is a high level of inflammation and environmental stress," he says. The first step of treatment, he says, begins at home. "Start by speaking to close friends and family or writing your problems down. But if that does not work, then seek a doctor's consultation where you can draw up a personalised plan for treatment. Everything does not work for everyone," he adds.

Some have found that music, art, learning a new language, reading or gardening helped them recover their cognitive health. For Chennai-based homemaker Ananya Nanda, 63, stress-busting came in the form of embroidery classes. "Taking online lessons and working with the needle helped improve my mental health and focus tremendously. Until then, I wasn't even able to remember something I had learnt just an hour ago," she says.

Difficulty in thinking and working the way you used to can be hard to handle. But not doing anything about your symptoms, or treating yourself without medical diagnosis, could make it worse. Instead of living with the fear that your brain is not working properly, doctors say it is best to come in for a consultation. "For every patient who comes in for diagnosis on time, there are many who don't," says Dr Sehgal. "Internet-based self-medication is harmful because Covid has a complicated relationship with the brain. One should consult a doctor before starting diets, exercises or medication." The choice is ultimately yours. ■